

CHAPTER 6

CREATING SPACE FOR GENDER DIFFERENCE AT ALL ORGANIZATIONAL LEVELS

ABSTRACT

Gender remains a politically charged and powerful ideological social identity dimension that categorically essentializes and reproduces opportunities and limitations in organizations. Addressed in Chapter 6 are assumptions about gender and ways that gender classifications and gender roles form and spill forth into both work and home life for an overlap of public and private spheres that disadvantage women and privilege men. Furthermore, femininity and masculinity constructs strengthen the power system that undergirds them, reinforces their meanings, and perpetuates behaviors, changing over time, across and within cultures, and over the life course.

In organizations, the glass ceiling metaphor has become a popular representation of inequality in the workplace for women, people of color and sexual minorities; a phenomenon expanded in recent years to include glass walls and glass cliffs to describe advancement barriers. Gender-neutral mindsets and blame-the-victim strategies found in organizations are examined, as well as the breadwinner role and intersectionalities of gender with social identity dimensions of age, ethnicity, and social class. Chapter 6 is divided into these subthemes: gender, roles, femininity, and masculinity; power and gender inequality at work, and effects on women; gender, parenting, and the second shift; the breadwinner role, hegemonic masculinity, and masculinity in crisis; gendered occupations and feminization of career fields; intersectionalities of gender with age,

ethnicity, and social class; and shattering schemas with androgyny and transgenderism.

Keywords: Federal Glass Ceiling Commission (FGCC); Gender; gender role; glass structure; second shift; sex; sexism; transgender; transvestite

This chapter overviews a vast collection of research across multiple disciplines and theory streams shaped by an understanding that gender is learned (not something one is born with) and examines specific ways that gender difference plays out in organizations and traverses private-public sphere overlap (home life/social and work life). For centuries, *sex* as a biologically defining characteristic among humans came to represent what it means to be a woman or a man — referring to genitalia, physicality, and reproduction. In more recent decades, *gender* is used (in contrast to *sex*) as a means for exploring the socially indoctrinated ways of considering what it means to be a man or to be a woman. An ideology of separate spheres long has justified separation of men to wage earning outside the home and women to nonwage earning labor inside the home (Goodwin & Risman, 2001). Kaufman (1994) explained gender as “the central organizing category of our psyches ... the axis around which we organize our personalities” (p. 144) and Hall (2000) explained it as encompassing the “full continuum of individual, group or organizational, and institutional or societal processes of differentiation and stratification” (p. 93) — while Goffman (1976) understood gender as a *performance* and a *display*.

Social constructionists have considered how deeply embedded power arrangements shape social inequity according to gender. Since the 1970s, there has been much attention to ways gender relations shape labor markets. The main axis of power in many areas of the world is male domination and subordination of women and some men (Connell, 1995, 2001). Much evidence has suggested that power arrangements forge gender disparity at work with women receiving lower earnings in devalued jobs and diminished prospects for career advancement over the life course. Women continue to enter the labor force in greater percentages than men (U.S. Department of Labor, 2000). Moreover, U.S. women *still* find themselves working a second shift at home, balancing career and home life; some serving as family breadwinners since the economic downturn during December 2007 through June 2009. Clearly, many men the world over no longer enjoy unlimited privilege

due to shifting world economies and experience un and underemployment, which diminishes their breadwinner status and supports redefined masculinity and male gender roles. Gendered occupations and feminization trends in women-concentrated fields also are explored. Morgan (1992) posited that experiences of men working in nontraditional occupations “can be treated as mini-dramas through which we can begin to explore the tensions and complexities of gender identities and the gender order” (p. 140). Gendered social identity intersections with dimensions of age, ethnicity/“race”, and social class also are explored since gender-based division of labor concepts must be viewed in socioeconomic contexts. Finally, this chapter examines unique gender identities that set themselves apart from traditional gender schemas: androgyny and transgenderism. Study findings of ways that these gender identities unfold in the workplace suggest that coworkers predominantly react to ambiguity and expectancy violations about gendered identity as biologically determined with confusion, hostility, and discrimination.

Gender in organizations is examined according to subthemes of: gender, roles, femininity, and masculinity; power and gender inequity at work, and effects on women; gender, parenting, and the second shift; the breadwinner role, hegemonic masculinity, and masculinity in crisis; gendered occupations and feminization of career fields; intersectionalities of gender with age, ethnicity, and social class; and shattering schemas with androgyny and transgenderism.

6.1. GENDER, ROLES, FEMININITY, AND MASCULINITY

Most human societies distinguish between female and male and ascribe gender-specific roles for each – so much so that people of Western cultures seem unable to imagine the possibility of an un-gendered self (Butler, 1990). Characterizing gender as “a routine accomplishment embedded in everyday interaction,” West and Zimmerman (1987) resolved that “doing gender” is unavoidable (p. 125). Such processes include categorizing femininity and masculinity so that people learn to experience, internalize, and sustain *as natural* this binary’s significance (MacKinnon, 2003); “prototypes of *essential* expression” (Goffman, 1976, p. 75, italics added). Defining masculinity and femininity challenges social researchers to avoid reductionism and generalization limitations, but nonacademics easily equate femaleness with femininity and maleness with masculinity (Hoffman, Hattie, & Borders,